Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort at a pretty picture, **indigo** often appears at a moment when we need **quiet**, or when we want to look **inward**. We do not always know why, though. Sometimes we know exactly why, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind an indigo stroke

The same indigo line on paper can mean **something completely different every time**, depending on what is happening in us just then. Sometimes it is **quiet**, sometimes **fear of the unknown**, sometimes simply the taste of the colour. That is why there is no point in reading a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Depth and quiet.

Large dark areas, circles heading towards the centre. The colour is calm and in no hurry.

Intuition and a hunch.

Oval shapes, an eye or a vertical axis in the middle of the paper. Something in you is opening and you do not yet know what.

Sadness and loneliness.

Dark, cold areas low on the paper, often without another colour. A colour that closes in on itself.

Fear of the unknown.

Dark, dense areas in which nothing can be made out. Like standing before a door you will not yet open.

Dreams and night.

Tiny light dots on a dark background, stars, a moon. Something that appears in the dark.

A need for distance.

An indigo wall or curtain across part of the paper. A colour that says “leave me alone for a while”.

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A dark colour does not have to mean a dark period

Perhaps you are drawn to its **fullness**. Perhaps you have finally found a colour that can carry a large area. Or you enjoy how a single light stroke stands out beside it. **From an indigo picture it cannot be determined** that you are sad, withdrawn or exceptionally intuitive. In work inspired by art therapy we are interested in your own experience. What happened while painting and what you recognise in the picture later.

A predominance of indigo alone is not enough for a verdict on whether it is calm or tiredness. **Maybe you wanted to rest**. Maybe the darkest tube simply fell into your hand.

I want it on canvas, I do not dare to put it on myself

An indigo picture and an indigo coat may ask two completely different things of you. On canvas you give space to an experience. In clothing you may feel that the colour connects you with a uniform or a role that you do not want. **The canvas can carry everything** you need to say in it, and you do not have to **buy anything new** for that.

On canvas you can give it enormous space and you do not have to accept at the same time the idea of how you yourself will look in it. **Canvas can be a safe place** where you allow expression in your own way.

Sometimes you want to wear it, sometimes just paint it. Sometimes you enjoy the night sky on paper and would not take a dark blue coat even for free. The two do not exclude each other.

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When indigo takes over the space

First let it come. Maybe you reach for indigo and have no idea why. Let it appear on the canvas **without any duty to explain** whether it is quiet, sadness, a hunch or a memory of the night sky above a country cottage. You can paint standing, on the floor, with your hand, a brush or a piece of cloth. What matters is what happens to you as you spread the colour, layer it or let it take up more room.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

Enveloped, or room?

A large indigo area can recall a pleasant sense of being enveloped. At other times it starts to feel heavy. A small trace can be precious and striking. It does not have to be large to carry an important feeling for you. Do I feel like extending the indigo, leaving it, or stepping back from it?

- **SATURATION**

Light, or rich?

By adding white you lighten the colour. By adding a suitable earthier tone you can mute it without it lightening markedly. These bring different experiences. Perhaps you do not need a lighter picture, just a less sharp colour expression. Try the change first in a small place.

- **THICKNESS**

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push, spread and layer. Thin paint creates transparency, running and unexpected paths. Sometimes you enjoy the resistance of the material. At other times the chance to let go of exact guidance. Neither alone reveals your character.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the indigo stroke looks. What matters is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One was made on a calm evening, the other after a day when you did not want to talk to anyone. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year it may suddenly dawn on you: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in myself then.” That is fine. **The picture will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

Neither is wrong and neither is right. Quiet, longing, a hunch and fear of the dark all belong to you and indigo can **carry everything**.

If very strong or painful feelings appear while you paint, **do not stay with them alone**. Talk about them with someone close or with an art therapist or therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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